

FAQs

TV tuner problems

Q. I have a Mercury TV tuner card. TV programs are captured with quite poor quality while recording in VCD mode. Changing the resolution has not helped. Can I directly save the video capture in DivX/MPEG4 format? I can't afford to record raw video as I have only 7 GB of free space.

Anoop

Via e-mail

A The quality at which you can capture video is largely dependent on the TV tuner card—cheap, low-end cards can never match the quality of a dedicated video capture card. The quality that you get is probably a limitation of your hardware. Try checking the driver configuration of your card to see if it offers a high-quality mode. You can do this by referring to the manual or the manufacturer's Web site (www.kobian.com). Capturing to DivX formats is very processor-intensive and requires a high-end CPU. You can download the latest DivX bundle from <http://www.divx.com/divx/>. After doing so, you can choose to encode into DivX from your TV tuner card's video capture settings—if your processor has the necessary power, you will be able to get good video encoding.

If your processor is not up to it, try using other codecs such as Intel Indeo 5.x or Radius Cinepak. These are not very heavy on the system and do not cut away too much visible clarity. Do note that encoding has very little to do with the video quality of live feeds. The codec only compresses the incoming video feed and further quality loss due to encoding is usually marginal (depending on the codec settings). The only other way encoding affects quality is if frame-drops occur due to slow processors. Thus, if you notice that the video feed itself is good quality and only the recording is poor, check the codec settings—changes such as using a different codec (keep away from the CPU-intensive ones), reducing the amount of compression and using more keyframes can tremendously improve quality. For better video quality, the best option would be to record video at higher resolutions, but you may have to upgrade the TV tuner card for that.

No picture

Q. I have a Compaq Presario 7500 running Windows XP Professional. It has 192 MB of RAM and a Compaq DVD/CD-ROM SD-612B. I use Windows Media Player version 9, but am not able to see movies on it—I can hear the sound, but there is no picture. Please help.

Ankush

Via e-mail

A The problem is with either the player itself, or the video codecs. This problem has been documented in earlier versions of Windows Media Player. Version 6.4 has been the most stable player till date, but most bugs seem to have been fixed in version 9. Also, until now only Release Candidates for the new version have been made available, which means it tends to have bugs. The final release will have at least the most apparent bugs fixed. You can download and install the earlier version from www.microsoft.com/windows/windowsmedia/download/default.asp and try watching the movies.

It would be difficult to determine whether it's a codec problem, since you have not mentioned what kind of movies you are trying to view—whether they are MPEG or AVI files, VCDs, or other formats. DivX videos that you download off the Internet could pose problems. There are several flavours of the codec such as SMR, FlaskMPEG, Microcrap, etc and if the videos are encoded with any of these, you would need to have the relevant codec installed. Since these codecs are very similar at the core, the player may open the file anyway and not display any picture. If the codecs seem to be the problem, try downloading and installing the Codec Pack of ELISOFT from <http://codecpack.elisoft.net/>.

Another problem, though unlikely, could be with the video files themselves if they are DivX files. Some video files get corrupted during transfers or encoding software add unnecessary headers. Open the file using VirtualDub (www.virtualdub.org) and save it as a different file using the Direct Stream Copy option for video and audio. This will cut out unnecessary bytes from the file that the player may not understand.

uninstalled it, but the screen has not changed back. Is there a way to solve this problem other than reinstalling Windows?

Abhradeep Biswas

Via e-mail

A The startup screen is not loaded from the logo.sys or logow.sys files. If the logo.sys file exists, it is used for the start-up screen, otherwise the default system screen is used. Thus, to revert back to the original display, simply locate and delete the logo.sys file. This could be in the root of drive C or in the Windows folder.

Noisy drives

Q. When I start my PC, the floppy drive makes some noise and after entering the BIOS password, it again makes some noise. After the operating system is loaded, when I start any application, my hard disk also starts making some noise. Please help me reduce these noises. I scan and defragment the hard disk regularly.

Kamalshil Lokhande

Via e-mail

A On starting the PC, after POST and after entering the BIOS password, the BIOS may be looking up the floppy drive to check if a bootable disk is inserted, causing the noise. You can disable this option from the BIOS and have it boot directly from the hard disk instead (see question, *Bootable floppy*). Also disable 'Boot Up Floppy Seek' from the BIOS. When you start applications, Windows would be transferring a lot of data to the hard disk to use the swap file. There is not much you can do about this. The hard disk will make noise every time there is heavy disk activity. Setting a permanent swap file after defragmenting the hard disk once may help, but will not reduce the noise much. If you have Windows 9x, to set a permanent swap file open **Control Panel > System > Performance > Virtual Memory**. Enable 'Let me specify my own virtual memory settings' and set the same value for the minimum and maximum swap file size. Ideally, this value should be two-and-a-half times the amount of RAM you have on the PC. Thus, if you have 64 MB of RAM, set this value to 160. 



Send your computing problems to
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or write to Digit,

D-222/2, Om Sagar, MIDC, Nerul-400
706, and we may answer it here!